

The Glass (Final Narrative)

What I see is not a building or an institution.
I see a system of flow.

At first, it appears as a reservoir high in the mountains. Rain falls from everywhere—countless streams feeding into it. The reservoir does not exist to store water for itself. Its purpose is simple: receive and release.

As the rain intensifies, the water level rises only enough to overflow, sending water outward in every direction—north, south, east, west. The reservoir is not the destination. It is a pass-through.

As I watched this in my mind, the reservoir flattened into something clearer: a perfectly transparent surface, like a pane of glass. Water poured onto the glass and passed over the edges immediately. Nothing pooled. Nothing accumulated. The glass stayed level, clear, and neutral. Its only job was to allow flow.

That is what these systems were meant to be: interfaces, not containers.

Then something changed.

Color appeared.

At first, faint stains—reds, blues, greens, golds—each entering from different streams. The colors thickened. They settled. They hardened. What was once clear glass began to carry weight.

The stains grew into dense, irregular forms—heavy, calcified growths clinging to the surface. The glass was no longer transparent. It had mass. It had storage. It had gravity.

Water that once passed through instantly now slowed, pooled, and collected. The system began pulling inward instead of releasing outward. What was meant to transmit began to retain. And the longer it held, the heavier it became.

These growths were not intentional. They emerged naturally once the system stopped functioning as a pass-through. Accumulation created shape. Shape created control. Control created distortion.

From the outside, people began mistaking the stained glass for the purpose itself—as if the surface, the color, the mass were the point. But that was never the design.

The moment the glass is struck—not chipped, but shattered—the illusion collapses. The growths fall away. What remains is obvious: the system was never meant to hold anything at all.

Once that is seen, it cannot be unseen.

Clarity does not come from replacing one structure with another. It comes from restoring transparency.

Flow resumes. Pressure equalizes.

And the surface returns to what it always was meant to be:
a neutral interface between need and response.